IOWN

The Morning Brief

MARCH 26, 2026

Rejection

Iran dismisses the 15-point plan and deploys counter-demands as the OECD quantifies the war's toll and 6,000 US troops head for the Gulf.

S&P 500	BRENT CRUDE	BITCOIN	GOLD	FEAR & GREED
6,568 ↑0.56%	~$102 ↓2.2%	~$71,000 ↑2.3%	~$4,560 ↑3.0%	10 · Extreme Fear

SECTION 01

Markets

WEDNESDAY'S RALLY UNWINDS OVERNIGHT AS IRAN'S REJECTION RESETS THE BOARD

Wednesday's session delivered a constructive tape: the S&P 500 rose 0.56% to approximately 6,568, the Dow gained 0.64%, the Nasdaq added 0.66%, and the Russell 2000 led at +1.22%. UVXY fell 3.34% as volatility compressed, and TLT rallied 0.96%—a meaningful bond bid that suggested the market was beginning to price a path toward de-escalation. Materials (+1.98%) and healthcare (+1.00%) led sectors, while energy was the only sector in the red (–0.44%). The overnight picture, however, has reversed: S&P futures are down approximately 0.76% to 6,590, Nasdaq futures are off 0.94%, and the VIX has climbed 7.34% to 27.19. The catalyst: Iran formally rejected the 15-point peace plan, issued its own five-point counter-demands, and the White House responded by threatening to "unleash hell" while deploying 82nd Airborne paratroopers toward the Gulf. Brent is climbing back toward $106 in Asian trading after settling near $102 on Wednesday. The de-escalation window that opened Monday is narrowing rapidly.

AMD +7.26% ON CPU PRICING POWER — THE SEMI ROTATION DEEPENS

AMD surged 7.26% to $220.27 on reports that both AMD and Intel are implementing CPU price increases of 10–15%, effective late March through April. Intel confirmed the adjustments, citing sustained demand and rising component costs. The pricing power narrative is particularly significant in the current environment: when semiconductor companies can raise prices into an inflationary backdrop without demand destruction, it signals genuine supply-demand tightness rather than speculative positioning. NVDA gained 1.99%, TSM added 1.31%, and QCOM rose 1.31%. However, LRCX fell 2.26% and KEYS dropped 1.83%—a divergence that may partially reflect Google's TurboQuant announcement, an AI memory compression algorithm that could reduce the memory footprint of large language models by a factor of six. Samsung and SK Hynix fell 5–6% in Asian trading Thursday. Analysts at Quilter Cheviot characterized the technology as evolutionary rather than re-

volutionary, but the near-term sentiment impact on memory-adjacent names is real. IOWN's semiconductor exposure is weighted toward logic and test equipment (LRCX, KEYS, ADI, NVDA) rather than pure memory, which limits direct TurboQuant exposure.

GOLD POSTS SHARPEST RALLY IN WEEKS — MINERS CONFIRM THE TURN

Gold surged 3.01% on Wednesday, its strongest single-session gain since the extended decline began. GLD closed at $416.29, placing spot gold near $4,560. Silver added 3.59%. IOWN's gold miners amplified the move: AEM gained 4.68% and GFI rose 3.96%. The rally was driven by a combination of dollar softening, crude oil retreat, and the mechanical exhaustion of forced liquidation that had weighed on the metal for nearly two weeks. Overnight, gold has pulled back toward $4,424 as the Iran rejection news strengthened the dollar and pushed oil higher—a reminder that gold's war-era trading pattern inverts the traditional safe-haven dynamic. When oil rises on escalation, the dollar strengthens and gold sells. When oil falls on de-escalation, gold rallies. J.P. Morgan and Goldman Sachs year-end targets remain well above current spot levels. The miners' outperformance on Wednesday—AEM and GFI both gaining more than gold itself—historically tends to confirm a developing floor in the underlying metal.

DEFENSE SURGES, ENERGY FADES — THE MARKET IS REPRICING DURATION

LMT gained 2.30% to $624.20 and GD added 1.81% to $352.50 on Wednesday, outperforming the broader market as the defense sleeve continued to absorb the war premium. Energy, by contrast, was the only sector in the red: VLO fell 2.98%, CVX declined 0.79%, and the XLE shed 0.44%. This divergence is informative: when defense rallies while energy fades on the same session, the market is pricing a longer conflict with declining oil disruption risk—or, alternatively, rotating from the direct commodity beneficiaries toward the fiscal beneficiaries. The digital asset sleeve recovered from Tuesday's Clarity Act selloff: HOOD surged 5.01% after its $1.5 billion buyback announcement, HUT gained 4.45%, and IBIT added 2.27%. COIN stabilized at $181.10 (+0.03%) after Tuesday's 9.76% plunge. PDD added 4.61% after reporting Q4 results that, while missing estimates, showed cheap-enough valuation to attract buyers.

S&P 500	**6,568 · ↑0.56% Wed · Futures ↓0.76% Thu AM**
BRENT CRUDE	**~$102 Wed close · Climbing back toward $106 overnight**
GOLD	**~$4,560 ↑3.0% Wed · Pulling back to ~$4,424 overnight**
AMD	**$220.27 · ↑7.26% · CPU price hikes 10–15%**
VIX	**27.19 · ↑7.34% premarket Thursday**
FEAR & GREED	**10 · Extreme Fear · Lowest reading of the conflict**

Wednesday gave the market a reason to hope. Thursday morning took it away. Iran's rejection, the troop deployment, and oil's overnight reversal suggest the five-day window may produce escalation rather than resolution. The portfolio is rotating accordingly: defense rising, energy fading, gold rebounding, semis finding pricing power. Avoid Erosion—the cost of chasing a ceasefire narrative that does not exist is higher than the cost of patience.

Geopolitics

IRAN REJECTS THE 15-POINT PLAN AND ISSUES COUNTER-DEMANDS

Iran formally rejected the US 15-point peace proposal on Wednesday, characterizing it as "maximalist" and "unreasonable," according to Al Jazeera. Iranian state media published the regime's own five-point counter-proposal: a halt to assassinations of Iranian officials, guarantees against future military action, reparations for war damage, a complete end to hostilities, and Iran's continued exercise of sovereignty over the Strait of Hormuz. The final point is functionally a non-starter for Washington—the US position requires Hormuz to remain an open international waterway. Foreign Minister Araghchi reiterated that no negotiations are taking place and that Iran does not plan to negotiate. The gap between the two frameworks is not a negotiating distance—it is a fundamental disagreement over the terms of engagement. The market priced de-escalation hope on Wednesday; it is now repricing the absence of a credible path to resolution.

82ND AIRBORNE DEPLOYS — WASHINGTON SHIFTS FROM DIPLOMACY TO COERCION

The White House responded to Iran's rejection with a sharp escalation in both rhetoric and posture. Press Secretary Leavitt stated that if Iran fails to "accept the reality of the current moment," Trump would ensure they are "hit harder than they have ever been hit before." At least 1,000 paratroopers from the 82nd Airborne Division have received deployment orders, joining approximately 5,000 Marines and thousands of sailors already heading to the region. The 82nd Airborne is the unit the Pentagon deploys for rapid insertion into contested territory—its mobilization signals operational preparation, not diplomatic leverage. Total US ground forces moving toward Iran could reach 6,000–8,000. The Financial Times assessed scenarios for a potential US assault on Kharg Island, through which 90% of Iran's oil exports historically passed. If the five-day pause expires Saturday without a framework, the combination of rejected diplomacy and forward-deployed ground forces creates the conditions for a significant escalation.

OECD AND ECB QUANTIFY THE ECONOMIC TOLL

The OECD released its interim economic outlook Thursday morning, providing the first comprehensive institutional assessment of the war's macroeconomic impact. Global GDP growth is now projected at 2.9% for 2026—unchanged from December, but the OECD noted that without the conflict, the projection would have been revised upward by approximately 0.3 percentage points. G20 inflation is forecast 1.2 percentage points higher than previously expected at 4.0%. US headline inflation is now projected at 4.2%, up from 3.0% in December. The UK faces the worst impact among G7 nations, with growth slashed to 0.7% from 1.2%. Separately, ECB Vice President de Guindos warned that while financial spillovers remain "contained," the conflict could trigger the "unravelling of interconnected vulnerabilities" and wider systemic stress—particularly through a sharp repricing of risk for leveraged borrowers and non-bank financial institutions. ECB President Lagarde signaled readiness to raise rates if the inflation surge persists. For IOWN, the OECD's 4.2% US inflation forecast is the number that matters: it confirms the Fed is locked in place at 3.50–3.75% through at least mid-year, with the risk tilting toward tightening rather than easing. Rate-sensitive holdings—NEE, BKH, ATO—face a more chal-

> lenging near-term environment than the March 18 dot plot suggested.

IRAN 15-POINT PLAN	**Rejected · “Maximalist and unreasonable”**
IRAN COUNTER-DEMANDS	**5 points · Reparations · Hormuz sovereignty**
US TROOP DEPLOYMENT	**82nd Airborne + 5K Marines · 6–8K total**
OECD GLOBAL GROWTH	**2.9% · 0.3pp uplift erased by war**
OECD US INFLATION	**4.2% forecast · Up 1.2pp from December**
5-DAY DEADLINE	**Expires ~Saturday March 29**

SECTION 03

On Our Radar

1. Friday is a dual-catalyst day: the five-day pause expires and PCE inflation data arrives. If Saturday passes without a ceasefire framework, the power plant strike threat returns and Brent could test the war-era highs seen earlier this month. PCE data for February will show whether the energy shock has begun feeding into broader consumer prices. A hot print combined with an expired deadline would be the most hawkish macro setup since the war began. CVX, VLO, OKE, GD, and LMT are the direct beneficiaries if escalation resumes; NEE, BKH, and ATO face further pressure if PCE surprises to the upside. Think Like an Owner—the portfolio is positioned through Saturday, not around it.

2. The OECD's 4.2% US inflation forecast changes the Fed calculus. The March dot plot projected one cut in 2026 with PCE at 2.7%. The OECD now projects 4.2% headline inflation—a 1.5 percentage point gap that, if realized, makes even one cut difficult to justify. Market pricing has already moved: fed funds futures show no cuts priced through year-end, with some probability assigned to a hike. If the OECD projection proves directionally correct, the rate-sensitive sleeve faces a structurally different environment than the one the portfolio was built for. Research Reveals Opportunities.

3. Google's TurboQuant memory compression algorithm is pressuring memory-adjacent names. Samsung and SK Hynix fell 5–6% in Asian trading Thursday. Micron dropped 3.40% Wednesday and fell further after hours. The algorithm reportedly reduces AI model memory requirements by a factor of six while improving GPU performance eightfold. LRCX (–2.26% Wednesday) has exposure to memory equipment demand. Analysts caution the impact is evolutionary rather than revolutionary, but the sentiment shift could persist through Google's detailed presentation at ICLR next month. Monitor LRCX and ADI for further weakness.

4. AMD's CPU pricing power is the constructive counter-narrative. When semiconductor companies raise prices 10–15% into a recessionary scare without demand destruction, it confirms supply-demand tightness that transcends the macro cycle. AMD's 7.26% move was the largest single-session gain for an IOWN holding in nearly two weeks. Combined with NVDA (+1.99%) and TSM (+1.31%), the logic-and-test semiconductor thesis continues to outperform. **The physical world matters.**

5. Fear & Greed hit 10—the lowest reading of the conflict. Sentiment has now been in extreme fear territory for the entirety of the war. Historically, readings below 15 that persist for more than three weeks have tended to precede significant recoveries, though the catalyst and timing remain uncertain. The current reading does not suggest an imminent turn, but it does suggest that the marginal seller is increasingly exhausted. Discipline, not impulse. Avoid Erosion.

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